

****Kids Using Artificial Intelligence to Strip Girls: A Phenomenon That Must Be Stopped Immediately****

****Kids Using Artificial Intelligence to Strip Girls: A Phenomenon That Must Be Stopped Immediately****

Now, it is enough to have a photo of the victim's face, any photo, a few minutes of patience, the right app, and the act – which is not a game but an act of brutal violence – is done. To remedy this, there are two levers that urgently need to be activated.

****Intervention by Guido Scorza, Member of the Guarantor for the Protection of Personal Data****
(HuffPost, November 2023)

Unfortunately, stories are increasingly bouncing from Spain to Italy and from Italy to the United States, multiplying at the speed of light: kids who "strip" girls thanks to increasingly user-friendly artificial intelligence applications and then share the photos in question through messaging apps, social networks, and pornographic sites. Now, it is enough to have a photo of the victim's face, any photo, a few minutes of patience, the right app, and the act – which is not a game but an act of brutal violence – is done.

An instant later, a drama begins for the victims, of which, in most cases, the budding digital perpetrators fail to perceive the magnitude and the various possible consequences.

Just in the last few weeks, it has happened in the Spanish town of Almendralejo, it has happened in Italy in Treviso, and most recently, in the United States in New Jersey, or rather, it has certainly happened everywhere, but these are some of the stories that have bounced in the media. However, the scale of the phenomenon is literally devastating and, above all, the trend shows exponential growth.

According to independent research recently published in the U.S. by Wired, in the first nine months of 2023, the number of artificially modified fake videos published on 35 platforms specializing in sharing this type of content increased by 54% compared to the previous year.

At the root of this surge is the spread of artificial intelligence services that enable the production of fakes and, above all, the increasing ease of use.

Needless to say, especially if the victim is a teenager – but the considerations are not different for adult victims – the risk that the dissemination of such a video irreparably destroys their life is enormous.

And it is especially pointless to beat around the bush: we are facing episodes of sexual violence that do not deserve to be considered less serious than those of physical violence and that, in any case, constitute the crime of distributing child pornography whenever the victim is a minor.

But the point, in the situation we are in, is not and cannot be the existing rules, which can, of course, always be improved; the point is that while the whole world is engaged in discussing these new rules, while every day the birth of a new commission is announced, while projects to govern the phenomenon multiply – for more or less noble reasons – hundreds – or perhaps thousands – of girls and boys are exposed every day to dramatic and unsustainable risks.

We need to intervene, and we need to do it immediately.

And, unfortunately, the regulatory initiatives just introduced in our legal system during the conversion into law of the so-called Caivano Decree – parental control tools on smartphones and age verification for access to pornographic platforms – do not seem destined to have any impact on the phenomenon.

There are two levers that urgently need to be activated.

1. The first concerns the integration into all platforms through which the content in question is normally disseminated – messaging apps, social networks, audiovisual content sharing sites – of technological solutions, now existing and reliable, that allow for the identification of "faked" content and report this circumstance to users. At least it should be known that the video in front of you, depicting a schoolmate naked and/or engaged in who knows what erotic acts, is or could be fake; this is not the solution to the problem but may mitigate its consequences.

2. The second concerns the accessibility of these differently intelligent digital manipulation tools – because here the expression "artificial intelligence" proves to be truly inappropriate – to a minor audience: it must simply be excluded without a second thought. Providers of this type of solutions must be required to equip themselves with effective age verification tools, and if they do not comply, they should be removed from the market. But this should not wait until we have, in a few years, the new European rules on artificial intelligence in full force, but today. And it is not a matter of being afraid of artificial intelligence but simply being aware that the most useful and valuable technologies in the hands of those who are unable to understand their potential and perceive the risks associated with their use can become a lethal weapon. It is, after all, the same principle for which we do not allow a child to ride a scooter or drive a car: the problem is not the danger of the means themselves but their danger in the hands of those who do not know and cannot, normally, know the rules and dynamics of operation.